My BASF Refinish Transformation Story:

How I Transformed BASF Refinish Team's Data into Insights and Awakened "the Sleeping Giant"

By: Adrian Fierro

When I stepped into the role of Head of Global Market Intelligence for BASF Refinish, I was prepared to redefine how we gathered data and converted it into informed business action. Having held previous positions within BASF Refinish, I had attained a solid familiarity with the industry and was eager to steer the global business by combining our latest data with the sharpest technological tools available. Over the course of several years, I strategically unlocked market insights through introducing new data software to the business, creating an Agentic AI Chatbot to support and equip sales, and leading the data forecasting for the Carlyle acquisition. Together with my team, I reimagined and transformed the role of market intelligence into a contemporary and agile branded department.

The Challenge I Inherited: *When my career started at BASF, we were often referred to as "the sleeping giant". While we were tied to the largest chemical manufacturer in the world, the BASF Refinish division was viewed as inert. Our struggle involved being:*

- **Too Dependent**: We passively sat as the number 4 product across the US market. Despite our high-quality products, we were seen as too expensive. Thus, we were overly reliant on our B2B and B2C partners' impetus to drive our own success.
- **Under the Radar:** In some markets we had 30%-40% market share. Yet, there were markets where we needed to build with little to no customer knowledge of our products.
- **Dormant:** We were seen as a company built around too many processes and not enough agility in our decision making—hence "the sleeping giant".
- **Reactive:** Our teams were often never first to market and typically were following trends set by our competitors.

My Transformation Impact: A Progression of Roles: *The depth of my industry knowledge grew from the breadth of my roles within the company. My impact was phased across three positions.*

Phase 1: Waking the Sleeping Giant: *BASF Refinish was losing market share as one of our vendors kept us as the #5 choice on their vendor list. I joined BASF Refinish as a Project Manager tasked with moving and saving **$57 million** of these at-risk sales.*

- My team and I built an **efficient data model and strategy** for a 3-4 month overnight system conversion, cross-validating CRM data against third-party sources to raise leadership's confidence in customer risk data from **60% to 80%.**
- During that time, we executed thousands of contracts and improved contract approval turnaround by **75%, reducing a 2 month process to 2 weeks.** We **retained 74%** of the business with our goal being 70%.
- After the conclusion of the project, I continued to lead multiple sales blitzes where we met with over **1300 business** and generated over **$500 million** in pipeline opportunities.

Phase 2: Diving into the Front Line: *As the Southern California Regional Business Manager, it was time for me to "walk the walk" of the automotive refinish industry. Data would provide the foundation guiding my twofold focus—proactively growing our market share and fortifying customer relationships.*

- I evaluated our CRM data to more effectively map and divide sales territory amongst my team and identified our key customers to initiate a tiered approach to customer service
- This tiered approach established transparent service level agreements that boosted customer satisfaction and prompted 3 of our vendors to move our product from **third to first on the shelf**.

- I introduced the use of third-party vendors that provided me with the data and insights relevant for potential sales opportunities to grow our market.
- My approach was data driven and practical—*and it worked*. I had **202% growth my first yea**r in the role and **112% growth the second year**.

Phase 3: Steering the Business with Market Intelligence: *My proven success as an agile leader and my no-nonsense approach to data gave me a seat on the Global Market Leadership Team as Head of Global Market Intelligence. I was able to transform this department into a current and credible team depended upon for both business insight and foresight.*

- I brought in new technological tools by building 20+ Power BI applications and new KPI Indicators that delivered new insights, repeatable measurements, and global uniformity.
- I modernized the department by investing in multiple third-party software and incorporated these into our tracking framework scrubbing social media, news, research, and trends.
    - I developed **AI agents that used this new software to automate** our manual research and **reduce our workload by 40%** allowing my team and I to focus on new insights and growth.
- BASF was searching for a group that would commence a new AI project. Having previously demonstrated my expertise in implementing AI, I was selected as the project lead and owner and jumped right into developing an agentic AI chatbot.
    - I connected our Salesforce CRM tool, third party intelligence platforms, and other internal software to a Microsoft Teams chatbot that could easily communicate with our sales team**. For the first time we had produced meaningful insights directly from CRM to our sales teams in North America.** This project was targeted to roll out in EMEA, LATAM, and APAC.
- My influence in market intelligence was not just visionary, but also essential. Annually, I owned and led our Market Refinish Database (MRD)—a robust database involving over 70 countries that critically focused on market sizing, market segmentation, and competitor sizing.
    - **During the Carlyle acquisition, this was the main trusted tool** that helped our company share our growth trajectory during the sale.

The Delivered Results: *While at BASF, I had held three distinct positions and this versatility allowed me to **live the life of my stakeholders**. Though my roles changed, my commitment to practical data driven growth was consistent.*

- **Financial Impact:** I led teams that saved **74% of $57M of revenue**, created pipeline opportunities of over **$500M**, and generated back-to-back growth for the Refinish business.
- **Strategic Influence:** I contemporized the Market Intelligence role from a mere tracking function to an agile contributor driving **400% growth** in MI tool adoption as well as steering influence in the Carlyle deal.
- **Efficiency:** My team and I streamlined processes and expedited contract writing by 75%. Within Market Intelligence I reduced our manual workload by 40% due to automation.
- **Visionary Leadership**: My leadership journey shaped BASF Refinish from both behind and within the frontlines of the business. After 11 years, the giant was no longer sleeping—it was awake and functioning with the latest technology. I had guided the transformation of the underperforming Southern California territory as a Regional Business Manager. Then, as Head of Market Intelligence, I developed strategy for global senior leaders while also serving those very sales representatives and managers I had once worked with daily by building the systems and tools they used to maintain and grow the business while leveraging the direction of the global outlook of BASF Refinish.